

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Micah

Micah

God announced judgment against false prophets, corrupt leaders, and rich people who oppressed the poor. Because of the sins of his people, God declared that destruction was coming. But after judgment, restoration would come.

Through Micah, God's Spirit gave a strong message of hope for Israel's future. The Lord promised to save the remnant of Israel (the people who remained faithful). They would return to their land and become God's renewed people. God also promised to defeat their enemies and send his ruler from Bethlehem. Micah declares with great force and simplicity that there is no God like the Lord.

Setting

Micah spoke his prophecies during the reigns of the southern kings Jotham (750–732 BC), Ahaz (743–715 BC), and Hezekiah (728–686 BC). All three kings ruled for many years. During this time, both Israel and Judah were characterized by moral and religious corruption. There was social oppression, political plotting, economic injustice, personal sin, deception, and betrayal.

Jotham was a fairly good king. However, he did not remove the high places where people worshiped idols instead of worshiping the Lord properly at the temple in Jerusalem. Because the Lord was not fully pleased with Jotham's rule, he allowed King Rezin of Aram and King Pekah of Israel to attack Judah (2 Kings 15:32–38).

Ahaz, Jotham's son, followed the sinful practices of the northern kings of Israel. He practiced evil acts, including child sacrifice, pagan worship, and fertility worship (2 Kings 16:1–4). After the Edomites and Philistines took control of areas in southern Palestine (2 Kings 16:5–6; 2 Chronicles 28:18), Ahaz made an alliance with Tiglath-pileser III, king of Assyria from 744 to 727 BC. Ahaz paid gold from the temple and royal treasury to Assyria as tribute (2 Kings 16:7–9). He also brought pagan altars into Jerusalem and interfered with worship of the Lord (2 Kings 16:10–13; 14–20).

Unlike his father Ahaz, Hezekiah was a righteous king. During his reign, Samaria fell to the Assyrians in 722 BC under Shalmaneser V and Sargon II. Later, in 701 BC, God rescued Jerusalem from destruction by Sennacherib, king of Assyria from 704 to 681 BC. Even so, Sennacherib destroyed about 46 cities in Israel and Judah (2 Kings 18:1–19:37).

God also healed Hezekiah from a serious illness. Later, however, Hezekiah unwisely welcomed messengers from the Babylonian king Merodach-baladan, who wanted an alliance against Assyria (2 Kings 20:12–21).

Before Samaria was destroyed, the northern kingdom of Israel was ruled by Pekah (752–732 BC) and Hoshea (732–722 BC). Under both kings, Israel continued in the sinful ways of Jeroboam I, who had led Israel away from God (2 Kings 15:28). During Pekah's reign, parts of northern Israel were taken into captivity (2 Kings 15:29). Pekah was later assassinated by Hoshea, who ruled until Samaria fell in 722 BC (2 Kings 15:30–31, 17:6).

As Micah had warned, the northern kingdom of Israel was destroyed, and its people were taken into exile. Hoshea rebelled against Assyria and asked Egypt for help. When Shalmaneser V learned of this, he attacked Samaria. After a siege of three years, the city fell in 722 BC. Hoshea was imprisoned, the Israelites were scattered throughout the Assyrian Empire, and people from other nations were brought into the land of Israel (2 Kings 17:5–6, 2 Kings 17:24–41). Israel's false worship led to its destruction and rejection by the Lord.

Summary

After the opening verse (1:1), each of the book's three main sections begins with a call to "hear" (1:2–2:13; 3:1–5:15; 6:1–7:6). Through Micah, the Lord announced judgment against Samaria, Jerusalem, wealthy oppressors, corrupt leaders, false prophets, and other nations. The people refused to follow God's ways or listen to his messages. God's judgment was certain: Israel would be ruined and sent into exile.

At the same time, Micah's message also contains hope (see 2:12–13; 4:1–8, 13; 5:2–15; 7:7–20). In the end, judgment would be replaced by God's grace, faithful love, forgiveness, compassion, and mercy. Israel would be restored, and God would fulfill his promises to Abraham and Jacob.

Author and Date

Micah came from Moresheth, a town about 35 kilometers (21 miles) southwest of Jerusalem. Some scholars believe that passages such as 4:6–8 and 7:8–20 show that a later editor completed the book during the early postexilic period (538–458 BC). However, this conclusion is not necessary. Other prophets before the exile also spoke about Israel returning from exile (see Isaiah 52:4–12; Hosea 11:10–11; Amos 9:11–15).

Micah used figures of speech to describe events. Micah often used figurative language, which makes

it difficult to identify the exact historical situations connected to each prophecy. Some prophecies were probably given before the destruction of Samaria in 722 BC (see Micah 1:1, 6; 6:16). The Assyrian invasion of Israel and Judah in 701 BC seems to appear in 1:10–15.

Micah's prophecy about the fall of Jerusalem (3:12) was spoken during Hezekiah's reign (728–686 BC) and was later mentioned by Jeremiah. The prophet Jeremiah mentioned it much later (Jeremiah 26:16–19). Micah's ministry seems to have occurred around the same time as Isaiah's ministry. The similarity between Isaiah 2:2–5 and Micah 4:1–4 supports this view.

Meaning and Message

Micah's message is clear: God's plans for his people will succeed. Through Israel and through God's chosen ruler (5:2), the nations will come to know the Lord. God will fulfill his faithful promises to Abraham and Jacob.

Like Isaiah, Micah taught that Israel's hope would come through judgment, not by escaping it. The people had become so corrupt that judgment was necessary for their future restoration. This was very difficult for the people to understand.

God desires a people who show moral and spiritual faithfulness. He will accept nothing less. Only God can make his people righteous, or right with him (see 2 Peter 3:13). Many years after Micah, God would send a "ruler over Israel," born in Bethlehem, to lead his people and bring them peace (see Micah 5:2–5).